Guardians of the Clay in Cuatzontitla:

Barriers and Commercialization Opportunities in Traditional Nahuatl Pottery

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Background

In the Nahuatl community of Cuatzontitla, Tamazunchale, in the state of San Luis Potosí, Mexico (population: 256 inhabitants), the traditional craft of producing clay *comales* (griddles) faces a significant risk of disappearing due to limited economic viability and a lack of generational succession.

- **Decline of traditional knowledge**: The erosion of traditional artisanal knowledge reflects a broader, well-documented trend across Mexico and Latin America, where Indigenous artisanal microeconomies face significant barriers to commercialization, exploitative intermediary practices, and disruptions in generational knowledge transmission (Fonart, 2020; Moctezuma Yano, 2021; UNESCO, 2021).

- **Scope and methodological approach**: By including all three active craftswomen in the community, this study achieves complete coverage of the local population of practicing artisans. This approach prioritizes qualitative depth and contextual validity over statistical generalizability.

- **Established community engagement**: The project builds on more than five years of ongoing engagement with the community, providing an essential foundation of trust and mutual understanding for the research process.



Research Question

- **Question:** What are the socioeconomic barriers and distribution opportunities that influence the commercialization of traditional pottery in the Nahuatl community of Cuatzontitla?

- **Objective:** To identify socioeconomic constraints and evaluate the feasibility of transitioning toward direct-sales models using low-complexity technologies.







Methodology

- **Approach and Research Design:** A qualitative, descriptive-exploratory study employing non-probability convenience sampling (N = 3). The unit of analysis was extended to include the artisan–family dyad to examine the intergenerational transmission of technical skills and cultural knowledge.
- **Fieldwork:** Five field visits were conducted between July and October 2026, following formal authorization from local community authorities.
- **Data Collection Techniques and Instruments:** Six in-depth, semi-structured interviews were conducted in person at the artisans' homes and workshops, with two sessions per artisan, each lasting 45–60 minutes. Data collection was complemented by field notes, photographic documentation, and audio recordings, all obtained with participants' informed consent.







Key Findings

- **Logistical Vulnerability**: Recurring economic losses resulting from product breakage during transportation via public transit, a process locally known as *ranchado*.
- **Commercial Precarity**: The physical demands of itinerant vending, compounded by aggressive bargaining in local marketplaces, can substantially reduce artisans' earnings. Prices may fall by as much as 60%, from MXN 250 to MXN 100 per comal.
- **Technological Barriers and Family Support**: Limited digital engagement among elderly artisans (aged 70+) constrains their access to digital marketplaces and broader commercial opportunities. However, intergenerational support from children and grandchildren offers a potential pathway to overcoming these barriers.





Conclusion

- **Alternative Proposal**: Willingness was identified toward an order-based sales model using a hybrid, bilingual catalog (Spanish–Nahuatl; digital via WhatsApp and printed for craft fairs), operated through the family network (grandchildren) to bridge the digital divide.
- **EAAMO Reflection**: Given adverse commercial conditions (breakage, transport strain, and haggling), the analysis demonstrates that the use of low-complexity technologies has the potential to redesign the market mechanism. This approach enables the elimination of information asymmetries, reduces transaction costs, promotes linguistic justice, and guarantees fair trade that dignifies Nahuatl artisanal work, with operational implementation remaining open for future phases.

References

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